

LIFE+TRAVEL
Maine's oyster trail

A collection of more than 80 restaurants, farms and oyster-centered attractions stretches along the state's coast.

REAL ESTATE
A peek into co-ops

Shareholders in a corporation have the right to occupy unit in a building.



LOOK TO THE SKIES

The Chicago Air & Water Show returns Aug. 16-17 to the lakefront. Our guide has all the details. [A+E](#)

ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE 2023



BIODIVERSITY VS. EXPANSION

In the Quad Cities, a proposed development near a bald eagle habitat divides a community



Top: Kelly McKay, an independent biologist, conducts a survey of the species at Milan Bottoms Preserve in Rock Island County on July 31. **Above:** A bald eagle takes a perch at the preserve. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

By Lily Carey | Chicago Tribune

Wading through knee-deep water, Kelly McKay squinted in the evening light as the sun began to dip below the horizon. All around him, herons and other migratory birds darted between the dead trees that rose above the water, while turtles took shelter in the marsh's tall grasses.

This is the Milan Bottoms, a massive wetland near the conjunction of the Rock and Mississippi rivers in western Illinois that's home to over 150 endangered and threatened species. It's also the largest known winter nighttime roost for migrating bald eagles in the lower 48 states.

Over the past year, McKay, a biologist who has done contract work with the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers and several state Departments of Natural Resources, has spent hundreds of hours documenting the wetland's wildlife in his free time. The wetland spans over 4,000 acres, owned by a patchwork of state and federal agencies as well as private parties. McKay, though, has limited his tracking work mostly to its southeastern edge, which backs up against Interstate 280, Illinois Route 92 and several developments — including a Bally's casino.

As the Milan Bottoms have flourished over the years, the surrounding city of Rock Island has struggled to bring in commercial revenue, leading local developers to build closer and closer to the wetland.

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Vaccine confusion as COVID cases rise

Mixed messages leave people unsure of what will be administered

By Lisa Schencker and Katherine Weaver
Chicago Tribune

Aaron Hardwick woke up one Tuesday in June and immediately knew something was wrong. He felt hot, and his stomach hurt. He soon tested positive for COVID-19.

"The fever, the insomnia and the chills, and the shaking, was out of this world," said Hardwick, 45, of Rogers Park. "That was something I've never had before in my life."

Hardwick said he was last vaccinated for COVID-19 in 2023. He'd like to get vaccinated again in the future to avoid reliving his recent illness. But he isn't sure if that's possible.

"I don't know what we're supposed to do," Hardwick said. "Can we get the shot? Are we supposed to? Who knows?"

With fall approaching and COVID-19 activity rising across the country, confusion over vaccines is widespread. Mixed messages from the federal government have left patients, doctors and public health leaders uncertain about how and which COVID-19 vaccines will be administered to whom in coming months, and what health insurance will cover. The shots can cost more than \$100 each without insurance.

Though COVID-19 vaccines released last year are still available at the moment and covered by insurance, the uncertainty surrounds who will be able to get updated vaccines in coming months — shots created to protect against more recent strains of COVID-19. Like flu vaccines, COVID-19 vaccines are updated regularly.

"I think there's still a lot of confusion among people who would be in the know about what to order, how much to order and the fact we don't know what's covered," said Dr. Emily Landon, an infectious disease specialist at UChicago Medicine, about ordering updated COVID-19 vaccines for the fall. "It's very difficult to make decisions about what to order if you don't know how many of your patients are going to qualify for a certain treatment or vaccine."

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INSIDE



EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

Football returns to the lakefront

What to watch for as Ben Johnson makes his game debut as Bears coach in preseason opener against the Dolphins. **Chicago Sports**

Zelenskyy: Ukraine won't cede any land

The Ukrainian leader dismissed the planned Trump-Putin summit, warning any negotiations must include Kyiv. **Nation & World**

Storefront sign restriction efforts debated

'Quality of life' issue for some, while others worry about overreach

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Driving past a gas station two blocks from her Chatham office, Ald. Michelle Harris can't see inside as bright green vinyl signs cover the station's windows, promoting pop, chips and tobacco products.

Similar obstructions abound on the storefront windows near her house. Light barely pierces through the tall orange stickers pushing items for sale inside a Family Dollar store, while massive photos of painted fingernails block the public's view into a beauty shop.

The veteran South Side alderman sighs as she drives by the stores. The signage that has popped up all over her ward in recent years has begun to cause a twofold problem, she said. It's become a safety issue that prevents the public and police from seeing inside businesses, and it's marred neighborhoods with tackiness that's bordering on blight.

"We know you do nails!" an exasperated Harris said as she drove past the salon last week. "You tell me that this would be something that you would be proud to have in any community?"

So, in a move she describes as a "quality of life" issue, Harris, 8th, is spearheading a citywide effort

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The windows of a tax preparation business in the 8600 block of South Cottage Grove Avenue in Chicago are covered with ads. There is a push to reduce the amount of ads on the windows of retail stores. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**